

4 Efficient Sorting

Efficient Algorithms · Wintersemester 2026–27

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Learning Outcomes

Unit 4: ***Efficient Sorting***

1. Know principles and implementation of *mergesort* and *quicksort*.
2. Know properties and *performance characteristics* of mergesort and quicksort.
3. Know the comparison model and understand the corresponding *lower bound*.
4. Understand *counting sort* and how it circumvents the comparison lower bound.
5. Know ways how to exploit *presorted* inputs.

Outline

4 Efficient Sorting

4.1 Mergesort
4.2 Quicksort
4.3 Comparison-Based Lower Bound
4.4 Integer Sorting
4.5 Adaptive Sorting
4.6 Python's list sort

Why study sorting?

- fundamental problem of computer science that is still not solved
- building brick of many more advanced algorithms
  - for preprocessing
  - as subroutine
- playground of manageable complexity
  to practice algorithmic techniques

Algorithm with optimal #comparisons in worst case?

Here:

- "classic" fast sorting method
- exploit **partially sorted** inputs

Part I

The Basics

Rules of the game

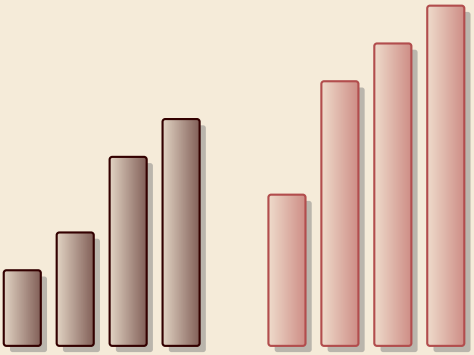
- **Given:**
  - array $A[0..n) = A[0..n-1]$ of n objects
  - a total order relation $\leq$ among $A[0], \ldots, A[n-1]$
    (a comparison function)
    Python: elements support `<=` operator (`__le__()`)
    Java: `Comparable` class (`x.compareTo(y) <= 0`)
- **Goal:** rearrange (i. e., permute) elements within A,
  so that A is *sorted*, i. e., $A[0] \leq A[1] \leq \cdots \leq A[n-1]$

- for now: A stored in main memory (*internal sorting*)
  single processor (*sequential sorting*)

4.1 Mergesort

Merging sorted lists

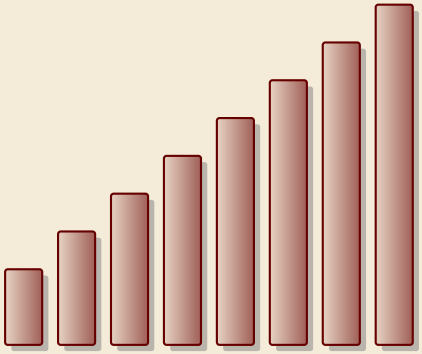




run1 run2 result

Merging sorted lists





run1 run2 result

Mergesort

```
1 procedure mergesort(A[l..r)):
2     n := r − l
3     if n ≤ 1 return
4     m := l + ⌊n/2⌋
5     mergesort(A[l..m))
6     mergesort(A[m..r))
7     merge(A[l..m), A[m..r), buf)
8     copy buf to A[l..r)
```

- recursive procedure
- merging needs
  - temporary storage *buf* for result (of same size as merged runs)
  - to read and write each element twice (once for merging, once for copying back)

Analysis: count *"element visits"* (read and/or write)

$$C(n) = \begin{cases} 0 & n \le 1 \\ C(\lfloor n/2 \rfloor) + C(\lceil n/2 \rceil) + 2n & n \ge 2 \end{cases}$$

same for best and worst case!

(precisely(!) solvable *without* assumption $n = 2^k$:
$C(n) = 2n \lg(n) + (2 - \{\lg(n)\} - 2^{1-\{\lg(n)\}})2n$
with $\{x\} := x - \lfloor x \rfloor$)

Simplification $n = 2^k$

$$C(2^k) = \begin{cases} 0 & k \le 0 \\ 2 \cdot C(2^{k-1}) + 2 \cdot 2^k & k \ge 1 \end{cases} = 2 \cdot 2^k + 2^2 \cdot 2^{k-1} + 2^3 \cdot 2^{k-2} + \cdots + 2^k \cdot 2^1 = 2k \cdot 2^k$$

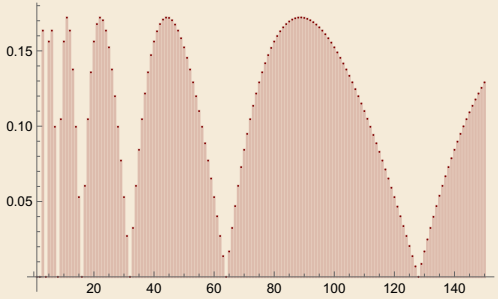
$C(n) = 2n \lg(n) = \Theta(n \log n)$ (arbitrary n: $C(n) \le C$(next larger power of 2) $\le 4n \lg(n) + 4n = \Theta(n \log n)$)

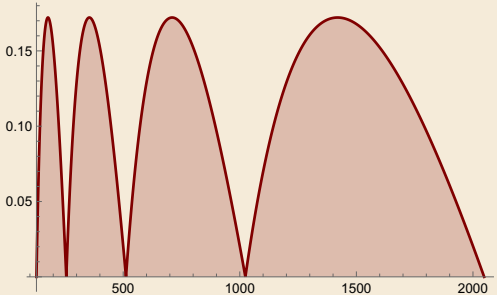
Linear Term of $C(n)$

Recall:

$C(n) \;=\; 2n\lg(n) + \big(2 - \{\lg(n)\} - 2^{1-\{\lg(n)\}}\big)2n \qquad$ with $\{x\} := x - \lfloor x \rfloor$

Plot of $2\big(2 - \{\lg(n)\} - 2^{1-\{\lg(n)\}}\big)$





$\rightsquigarrow$ Can prove: $C(n) \;\le\; 2n\lg n + 0.172n$

Mergesort – Discussion

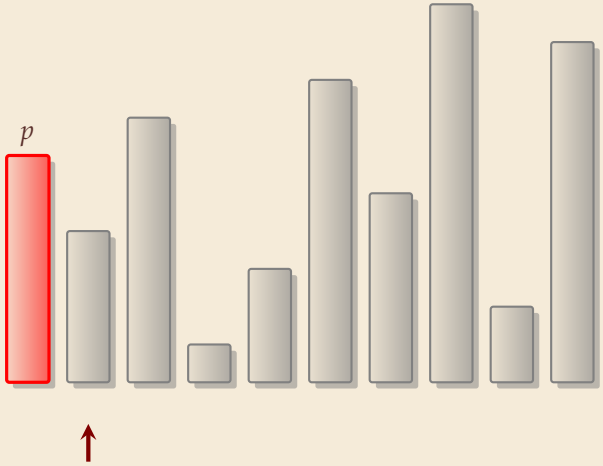
- optimal time complexity of $\Theta(n \log n)$ in the worst case
- *stable* sorting method — i. e., retains relative order of equal-key items
- memory access is sequential (scans over arrays)
- requires $\Theta(n)$ extra space

there are in-place merging methods,
but they are substantially more complicated
and not (widely) used

4.2 Quicksort

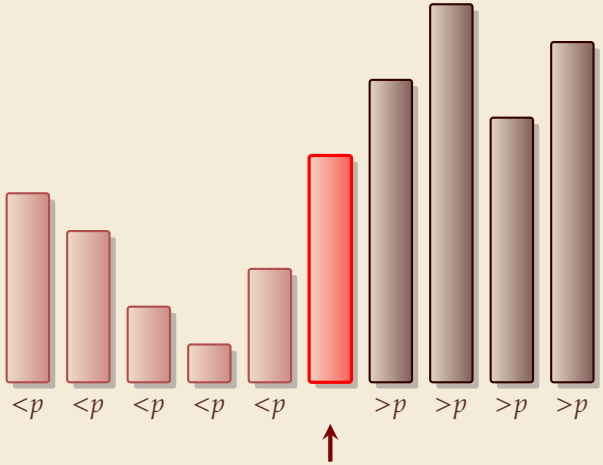
Partitioning around a pivot





Partitioning around a pivot





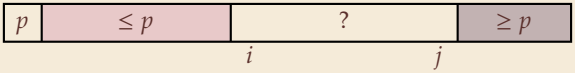
- no extra space needed
- visits each element once
- returns rank/position of pivot

Partitioning – Detailed code

Beware: details easy to get wrong; use this code! (if you ever have to)

```
1  procedure partition(A, b):
2      // input: array A[0..n), position of pivot b ∈ [0..n)
3      swap(A[0], A[b])
4      i := 0,    j := n
5      while true do
6          do i := i + 1 while i < n and A[i] < A[0]
7          do j := j − 1 while j ≥ 1 and A[j] > A[0]
8          if i ≥ j then break     (goto 11)
9          else swap(A[i], A[j])
10     end while
11     swap(A[0], A[j])
12     return j
```

Loop invariant (5–10): A



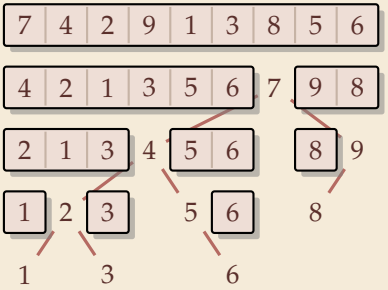
Quicksort

```
1 procedure quicksort(A[l..r)):
2     if r − l ≤ 1 then return
3     b := choosePivot(A[l..r))
4     j := l + partition(A[l..r), b)
5     quicksort(A[l..j))
6     quicksort(A[j + 1..r))
```

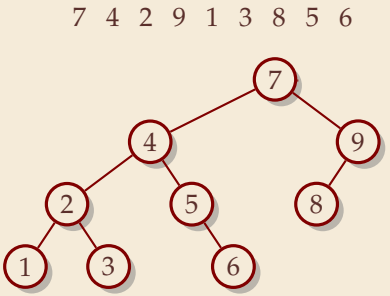
- recursive procedure
- choice of pivot can be
  - fixed position ⇝ dangerous!
  - random
  - more sophisticated, e. g., median of 3

Quicksort & Binary Search Trees

Quicksort



Binary Search Tree (BST)

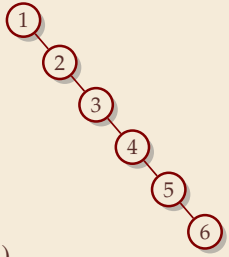


- recursion tree of quicksort = binary search tree from successive insertion
- comparisons in quicksort = comparisons to built BST
- comparisons in quicksort $\approx$ comparisons to search each element in BST

Quicksort – Worst Case

- Problem: BSTs can degenerate
- Cost to search for k is k

$\rightsquigarrow$ Total cost $\displaystyle\sum_{k=1}^{n} k = \frac{n(n+1)}{2} \sim \frac{1}{2}n^2$



$\rightsquigarrow$ quicksort worst-case running time is in $\Theta(n^2)$

terribly slow!

But, we can fix this:

Randomized quicksort:

- choose a *random pivot* in each step

$\rightsquigarrow$ same as randomly *shuffling* input before sorting

Randomized Quicksort – Analysis

- cost measure: element visits (as for mergesort)
- $C(n)$ = #element visits when sorting n randomly permuted elements
  = cost of searching every element in BST built from input

$\rightsquigarrow$ quicksort needs $\sim 2\ln(2) \cdot n \lg n \approx 1.39 n \lg n$ *in expectation*
(see analysis of C_n in Unit 3!)

- also: very unlikely to be much worse:
  e. g., one can prove: $\Pr[\text{cost} > 10n \lg n] = O(n^{-2.5})$
  distribution of costs is "concentrated around mean"
  - even stronger bounds known  **McDiarmid, Hayward**: *Large Deviations for Quicksort*, J. Algorithms 21(3) **1996**
- intuition: have to be *constantly* unlucky with pivot choice

Quicksort – Discussion

- fastest general-purpose method
- $\Theta(n \log n)$ average case
- works *in-place* (no extra space required)
- memory access is sequential (scans over arrays)
- $\Theta(n^2)$ worst case (although extremely unlikely)
- not a *stable* sorting method

Open problem: Simple algorithm that is fast, stable and in-place.

4.3 Comparison-Based Lower Bound

Lower Bounds

- **Lower bound:** mathematical proof that *no algorithm* can do better.
  - very powerful concept: bulletproof *impossibility* result
    - $\approx$ *conservation of energy* in physics
  - **(unique?) feature of computer science:**
    for many problems, solutions are known that (asymptotically) **achieve the lower bound**
  - $\rightsquigarrow$ can speak of "*optimal* algorithms"

- To prove a statement about *all algorithms*, we must precisely define what that is!

- already know one option: the word-RAM model

- Here: use a simpler, more restricted model.

The Comparison Model

- In the *comparison model* data can only be accessed in two ways:
  - comparing two elements
  - moving elements around (e. g. copying, swapping)
  - Cost: number of comparisons.

That's good!
Keeps algorithms general!

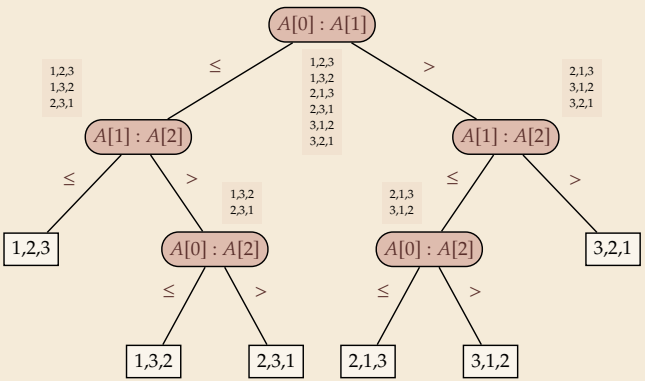
- This makes very few assumptions on the kind of objects we are sorting.
- Mergesort and Quicksort work in the comparison model.

⇝ Every comparison-based sorting algorithm corresponds to a ***decision tree***.

- only model comparisons ⇝ ignore data movement
- nodes = comparisons the algorithm does
- child links = outcomes of comparison
- leaf = unique initial input permutation compatible with comparison outcomes
- next comparisons can depend on outcomes ⇝ child subtrees can look different

Comparison Lower Bound

Example: Comparison tree for a sorting method for $A[0..2]$:



- Execution = follow a path in comparison tree.

  ⇝ height of comparison tree = worst-case # comparisons

- comparison trees are *binary* trees

  ⇝ ℓ leaves ⇝ height $\geq \lceil \lg(\ell) \rceil$

- comparison trees for sorting method must have $\geq n!$ leaves

  ⇝ height $\geq \lg(n!) \sim n \lg n$

more precisely: $\lg(n!) = n \lg n - \lg(e)n + O(\log n)$

- Mergesort achieves $\sim n \lg n$ comparisons ⇝ asymptotically comparison-optimal!

How tight is the lower bound?

Worst-case #comparisons to sort n elements:

	comparisons	$\approx n \lg n - c \cdot n$
Lower bound $\lceil \lg n! \rceil$	$n \lg n - n \lg e + O(\log n)$	$c = \lg e \approx 1.443$
Mergesort (top-down)	$n\lceil \lg n \rceil - 2^{\lceil \lg n \rceil} + 1$	$c \in [0.91, 1]$
Binary insertion (#cmps only!)	$\sum_{k=1}^{n} \lceil \lg k \rceil = n\lceil \lg n \rceil - 2^{\lceil \lg n \rceil} + 1$	the same!
Merge-insertion (Ford–Johnson)	$n \lg n - (3 - \lg 3)\, n + O(\log n)$ (for best n)	$c \in [1.329, 1.415]$
Group-insertion (Sergeev 2020/21)	$\lg n! + o(n)$	$c \to \lg e$

- Merge-insertion is *exactly* optimal for $n \leq 15$ and $n = 20, 21$, but *not* for $n = 47$ (Manacher 1979).
- In 2020, Sergeev announced an algorithm with $\lg n! + o(n)$ comparisons
  long and intricate proof, only asymptotically better
- the $O(n)$ gap is irrelevant for running time – but it is the oldest question about sorting.

Ford, Johnson: *A Tournament Problem*, Amer. Math. Monthly 66(5) **1959**

Manacher: *The Ford–Johnson Sorting Algorithm Is Not Optimal*, J. ACM 26(3) **1979**

Sergeev: *On the Upper Bound of the Complexity of Sorting*, Comput. Math. Math. Phys. 61(2) / ECCC TR20-096 **2021**

4.4 Integer Sorting

How to beat a lower bound

- Does the above lower bound mean, sorting always takes time $\Omega(n \log n)$?

- **Not necessarily;** only in the *comparison model!*
  - ⇝ Lower bounds show where to *change* the model!

- Here: sort n **integers**
  - can do *a lot* with integers: add them up, compute averages, . . . (full power of word-RAM)
  - ⇝ we are **not** working in the comparison model
  - ⇝ *above lower bound does not apply!*

  - but: a priori unclear how much arithmetic helps for sorting . . .

Counting sort

- Important parameter: size/range of numbers
  - numbers in range $[0..U) = \{0, \ldots, U-1\}$ typically $U = 2^b$ $\rightsquigarrow$ b-bit binary numbers
- We can sort n integers in $\Theta(n+U)$ time and $\Theta(U)$ space when $b \leq w$:

word size

Counting sort

```
1  procedure countingSort(A[0..n)):
2      // A contains integers in range [0..U).
3      C[0..U) := new integer array, initialized to 0
4      // Count occurrences
5      for i := 0,...,n-1
6          C[A[i]] := C[A[i]] + 1
7      i := 0 // Produce sorted list
8      for k := 0,...U-1
9          for j := 1,...C[k]
10             A[i] := k; i := i + 1
```

- *count* how often each *possible* value occurs
- produce sorted result directly from counts
- circumvents lower bound by using integers as array index / pointer offset

$\rightsquigarrow$ Can sort n integers in range $[0..U)$ with $U = O(n)$ in time and space $\Theta(n)$.

Larger Universes: Radix Sort

- ***MSD Radix Sort:***
  - split numbers into base-R "digits"
  - Use counting sort on most significant digit
    (with variant of counting sort that moves full number)
  - $\rightsquigarrow$ integers sorted with respect to first digit
  - recurse on sublist for each digit value, using next digit for counting sort

$\rightsquigarrow$ After $\lfloor \log_R(U) \rfloor + 1$ levels of counting sort, fully sorted!

- For $R = O(n)$ (hence $R \leq 2^w$), all counting sort calls on the same level cost total of $O(n)$ time
  (requires care: reuse C across the small subproblems instead of re-initializing it)

$\rightsquigarrow$ total time $O(n \log_R(U)) = O\left(n \frac{\log(U)}{\log(R)}\right)$

$\rightsquigarrow$ $O(n)$ time sorting possible for numbers in range $U = O(n^c)$ for constant c.

Integer Sorting – State of the art

Algorithm theory

- integer sorting on the w-bit word-RAM
- suppose $U = 2^w$, but w can be an arbitrary function of n
- how fast can we sort n such w-bit integers on a w-bit word-RAM?
  - for $w = O(\log n)$: linear time (*radix/counting sort*)
  - for $w = \Omega(\log^{2+\varepsilon} n)$: linear time (*signature sort*)
  - for w in between: can do $O(n\sqrt{\lg \lg n})$ (randomized, very complicated algorithm)
    don't know if that is best possible!

Andersson, Hagerup, Nilsson, Raman: *Sorting in Linear Time?*, J. Comput. Syst. Sci. 57(1) **1998**

Han, Thorup: *Integer Sorting in $O(n\sqrt{\log \log n})$ Expected Time and Linear Space*, FOCS **2002**

Han: *Deterministic Sorting in $O(n \log \log n)$ Time and Linear Space*, J. Algorithms 50(1) **2004**

* * *

. . . for the rest of this unit: back to the comparisons model!

Part II

Exploiting presortedness

4.5 Adaptive Sorting

Adaptive sorting

- Comparison lower bound also holds for the *average case* $\rightsquigarrow$ $\lg(n!)$ cmps necessary
- Mergesort and Quicksort from above use $\Theta(n \lg n)$ cmps even in best case



Can we do better if the input is already "almost sorted"?

Scenarios where this may arise naturally:

- Append new data as it arrives, regularly sort entire list (e. g., log files, database tables)
- Compute summary statistics of time series of measurements that change slowly over time (e. g., weather data)
- Merging locally sorted data from different servers (e. g., map-reduce frameworks)

$\rightsquigarrow$ Ideally, algorithms should *adapt* to input: *the more sorted the input, the faster the algorithm*

. . . but how to do that!?

Warmup: check for sorted inputs

- Any method could first check if input already completely in order!
  - Best case becomes $\Theta(n)$ with $n-1$ comparisons!
  - Usually $n-1$ extra comparisons and pass over data "wasted"
  - Only catches a single, extremely special case ...

- For divide & conquer algorithms, could check in each recursive call!
  - Potentially exploits partial sortedness!
  - usually adds $\Omega(n \log n)$ extra comparisons



For Mergesort, can instead check before merge with a **single** comparison

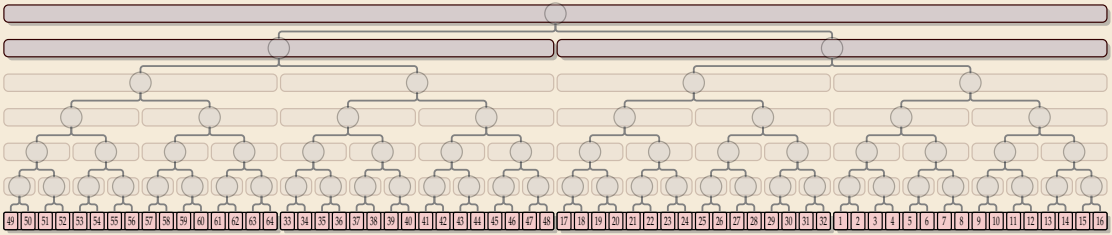
- If last element of first run $\leq$ first element of second run, skip merge

How effective is this idea?

```
1  procedure mergesortCheck(A[l..r)):
2      n := r − l
3      if n ≤ 1 return
4      m := l + ⌊n/2⌋
5      mergesortCheck(A[l..m))
6      mergesortCheck(A[m..r))
7      if A[m − 1] > A[m]
8          merge(A[l..m), A[m..r), buf)
9          copy buf to A[l..r)
```

Mergesort with sorted check – Analysis

- Simplified cost measure: *merge cost* = size of output of merges
  ≈ number of comparisons
  ≈ number of memory transfers / cache misses
- Example input: $n = 64$ numbers in sorted *runs* of 16 numbers each:





Sorted check can help a lot!

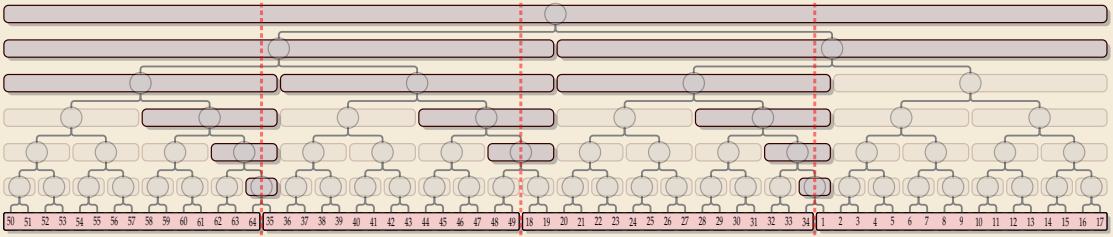
Alignment issues

- In previous example, each run of length ℓ saved us $\ell \lg(\ell)$ in merge cost.
  - = exactly the cost of *creating* this run in mergesort had it not already existed
  - $\rightsquigarrow$ best savings we can hope for!

$\rightsquigarrow$ Are overall merge costs $\mathcal{H}(\ell_1, \ldots, \ell_r) := \underbrace{n \lg(n)}_{\text{mergesort}} - \underbrace{\sum_{i=1}^{r} \ell_i \lg(\ell_i)}_{\text{savings from runs}}$?

(ℓ_i = length of ith run)

Unfortunately, not quite:



Merge costs:



Bottom-Up Mergesort

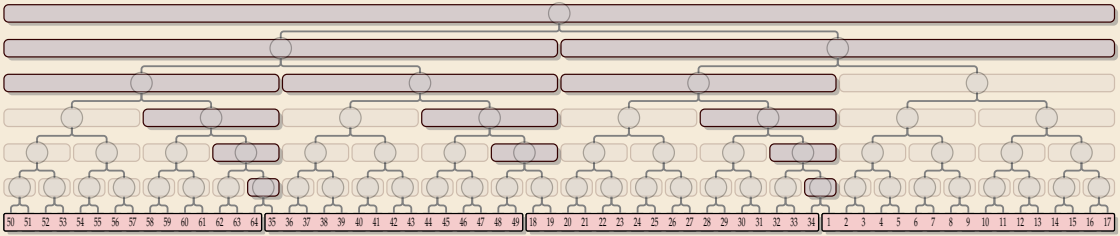
- Can we do better by explicitly detecting runs?

```
1  procedure bottomUpMergesort(A[0..n)):
2      Q := new Queue // runs to merge
3      // Phase 1: Enqueue singleton runs
4      for i = 0, ..., n − 1 do
5          Q.enqueue((i, i + 1))
6      // Phase 2: Merge runs level−wise
7      while Q.size() ≥ 2
8          Q′ := new Queue
9          while Q.size() ≥ 2
10             (i1, j1) := Q.dequeue()
11             (i2, j2) := Q.dequeue()
12             merge(A[i1..j1), A[i2..j2), buf)
13             copy buf to A[i1..j2)
14             Q′.enqueue((i1, j2))
15         if ¬Q.isEmpty() // lonely run
16             Q′.enqueue(Q.dequeue())
17         Q := Q′
```

```
1  procedure naturalMergesort(A[0..n)):
2      Q := new Queue;  i := 0          find run A[i..j) starting at i
3      while i < n
4          j := i + 1
5          while j<n ∧ A[j] ≥ A[j−1] do j := j+1
6          Q.enqueue((i, j));  i := j
7      while Q.size() ≥ 2
8          Q′ := new Queue
9          while Q.size() ≥ 2
10             (i1, j1) := Q.dequeue()
11             (i2, j2) := Q.dequeue()
12             merge(A[i1..j1), A[i2..j2), buf)
13             copy buf to A[i1..j2)
14             Q′.enqueue((i1, j2))
15         if ¬Q.isEmpty() // lonely run
16             Q′.enqueue(Q.dequeue())
17         Q := Q′
```

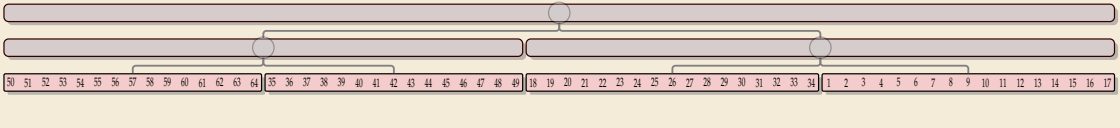
Natural Bottom-Up Mergesort – Analysis

- Works well for runs of roughly equal size, regardless of alignment . . .



Merge costs:

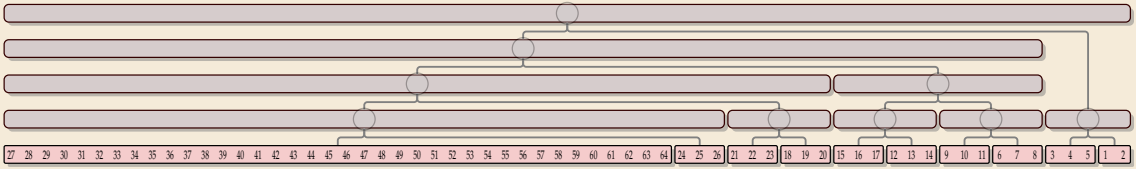


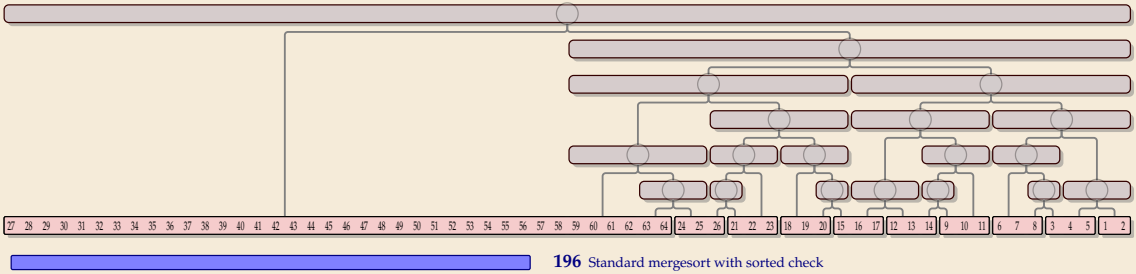




Natural Bottom-Up Mergesort – Analysis [2]

- . . . but less so for widely varying run lengths



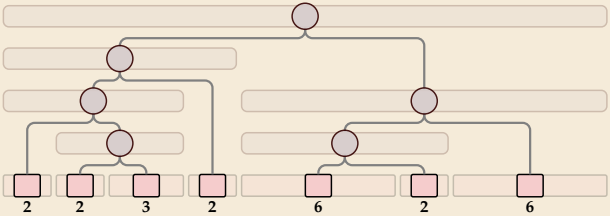


. . . can't we have both at the same time?!

Good merge orders

Let's take a step back and breathe.

- Conceptually, there are two tasks:
  1. Detect and use existing runs in the input $\rightsquigarrow$ $\ell_1, \ldots, \ell_r$ (easy) ✓
  2. **Determine a favorable *order of merges* of runs** ("automatic" in top-down mergesort)



Merge cost = total area of 

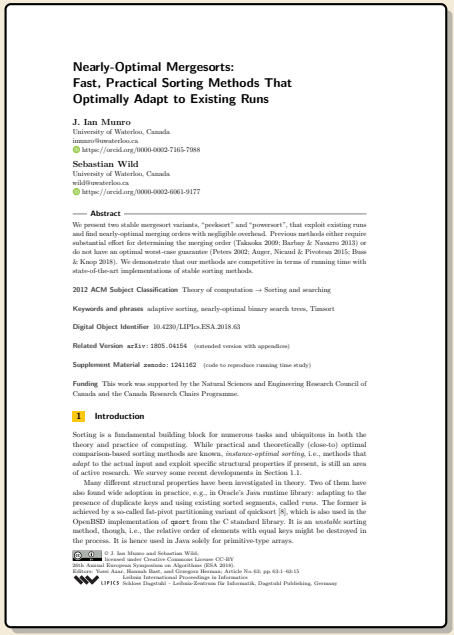
= total length of paths to all array entries

$$= \sum_{w \text{ leaf}} weight(w) \cdot depth(w)$$

$\rightsquigarrow$ *optimal* merge tree = optimal *binary search tree* for leaf weights $\ell_1, \ldots, \ell_r$ (optimal expected search cost)

well-understood problem with known algorithms

Nearly-Optimal Mergesort



Nearly-Optimal Mergesorts: Fast, Practical Sorting Methods That Optimally Adapt to Existing Runs

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Abstract

We present two stable mergesort variants, "peeksort" and "powersort", that exploit existing runs and find nearly-optimal merging orders with negligible overhead. Previous methods either require substantial effort for determining the merging order (Takaoka 2009; Barbay & Navarro 2013) or do not have an optimal worst-case guarantee (Peters 2002; Auger, Nicaud & Pivoteau 2015; Buss & Knop 2018). We demonstrate that our methods are competitive in terms of running time with state-of-the-art implementations of stable sorting methods.

2012 ACM Subject Classification Theory of computation → Sorting and searching

Keywords and phrases adaptive sorting, nearly-optimal binary search trees, Timsort

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Supplement Material zenodo: 1241162 (code to reproduce running time study)

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1 Introduction

Sorting is a fundamental building block for numerous tasks and ubiquitous in both the theory and practice of computing. While practical and theoretically (close-to) optimal comparison-based sorting methods are known, *instance-optimal sorting*, i.e., methods that *adapt* to the actual input and exploit specific structural properties if present, is still an area of active research. We survey some recent developments in Section 1.1.

Many different structural properties have been investigated in theory. Two of them have also found wide adoption in practice, e.g., in Oracle's Java runtime library: adapting to the presence of duplicate keys and using existing sorted segments, called *runs*. The former is achieved by a so-called fat-pivot partitioning variant of quicksort [8], which is also used in the OpenBSD implementation of `qsort` from the C standard library. It is an unstable sorting method, though, i.e., the relative order of elements with equal keys might be destroyed in the process. It is hence used in Java solely for primitive-type arrays.

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26th Annual European Symposium on Algorithms (ESA 2018).
Editors: Yossi Azar, Hannah Bast, and Grzegorz Herman; Article No. 63; pp. 63:1–63:15
Leibniz International Proceedings in Informatics
LIPICS Schloss Dagstuhl – Leibniz-Zentrum für Informatik, Dagstuhl Publishing, Germany

- In 2018, with Ian Munro, I combined research on nearly-optimal BSTs with mergesort

⇝ 2 new algorithms: *Peeksort* and *Powersort*

- both adapt provably optimal to existing runs even in worst case:
  mergecost $\leq \mathcal{H}(\ell_1, \ldots, \ell_r) \; + \; 2n$
- both are lightweight extensions of existing methods with negligible overhead
- both fast in practice

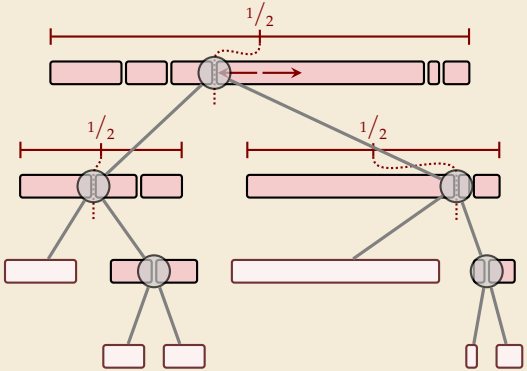
Munro, Wild: *Nearly-Optimal Mergesorts: Fast, Practical Sorting Methods That Optimally Adapt to Existing Runs*, ESA **2018**

Peeksort

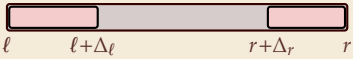
- based on top-down mergesort
- "peek" at middle of array & find closest run boundary



⇝ split there and recurse
(instead of at midpoint)



- can avoid scanning runs repeatedly:
  - find full run straddling midpoint
  - remember length of known runs at boundaries

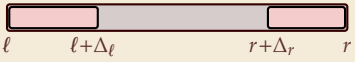


⇝ with clever recursion, scan each run only once.

Peeksort – Code

```
1  procedure peeksort(A[ℓ..r), Δ_ℓ, Δ_r):
2      if r − ℓ ≤ 1 then return
3      if ℓ + Δ_ℓ == r ∨ ℓ == r + Δ_r then return
4      m := ℓ + ⌊(r − ℓ)/2⌋
5      i := { ℓ + Δ_ℓ                 if ℓ + Δ_ℓ ≥ m
            { extendRunLeft(A, m)     else
6      j := { r + Δ_r                 if r + Δ_r ≤ m
            { extendRunRight(A, m)    else
7      g   := { i   if m − i < j − m
              { j   else
8      Δ_g := { j − i   if m − i < j − m
              { i − j   else
9      peeksort(A[ℓ..g), Δ_ℓ, Δ_g)
10     peeksort(A[g, r), Δ_g, Δ_r)
11     merge(A[ℓ, g), A[g..r), buf)
12     copy buf to A[ℓ..r)
```

- Parameters:



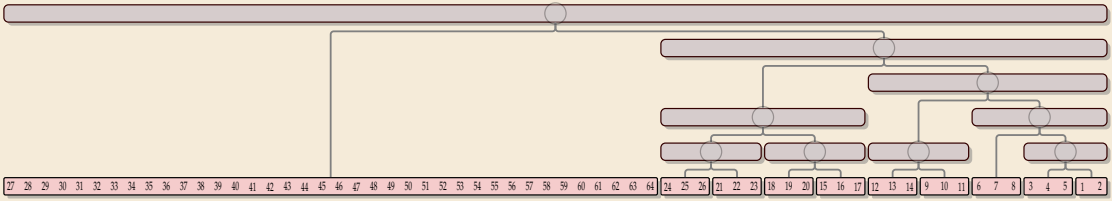
- initial call:
  peeksort($A[0..n)$, Δ_0, Δ_n) with
  Δ_0 = extendRunRight(A, 0)
  Δ_n = extendRunLeft(A, $n-1$) $-$ n
- helper procedure

```
1  procedure extendRunRight(A[0..n), i):
2      j := i + 1
3      while j < n ∧ A[j − 1] ≤ A[j]
4          j := j + 1
5      return j // A[i..j) is a run
```

(extendRunLeft similar)

Peeksort – Analysis

- Consider tricky input from before again:



- One can prove: Mergecost always $\leq \mathcal{H}(\ell_1, \ldots, \ell_r) + 2n$

$\rightsquigarrow$ We can have the best of both worlds!

4.6 Python's list sort

Sorting in Python . . . and JavaScript

- *CPython*
  - *Python* is only a *specification* of a programming language
  - The Python Foundation maintains *CPython* as the official reference implementation
  - If you don't specifically install something else, `python` will be CPython
- part of Python are `list.sort` resp. `sorted` built-in functions
  - implemented in C
  - use *Timsort*, custom Mergesort variant by Tim Peters



Sept 2021: **Python uses *Powersort*!**
since CPython 3.11 and PyPy 7.3.6



April 2026: **Chrome's V8 too!**
`Array.prototype.sort`
in Chrome, Chromium, Edge, Node.js, . . .
since Chromium 149

also: Apple's WebKit (Safari), NumPy, AssemblyScript, . . .


msg400864 - (view) Author: Tim Peters (tim.peters) * Date: 2021-09-01 19:43

I created a PR that implements the powersort merge strategy:

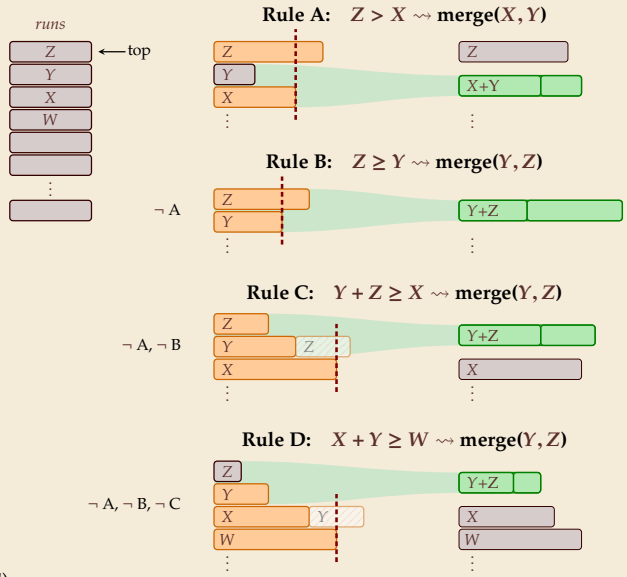
https://github.com/python/cpython/pull/28108

Across all the time this issue report has been open, that strategy continues to be the top contender. Enough already ;-) It's indeed a more difficult change to make to the code, but that's in relative terms. In absolute terms, it's not at all a hard change.

Laurent, if you find that some variant of ShiversSort actually runs faster than that, let us know here! I'm a big fan of Vincent's innovations too, but powersort seems to do somewhat better "on average" than even his length-adaptive ShiversSort (and implementing that too would require changing code outside of merge_collapse()).

Timsort (original version)

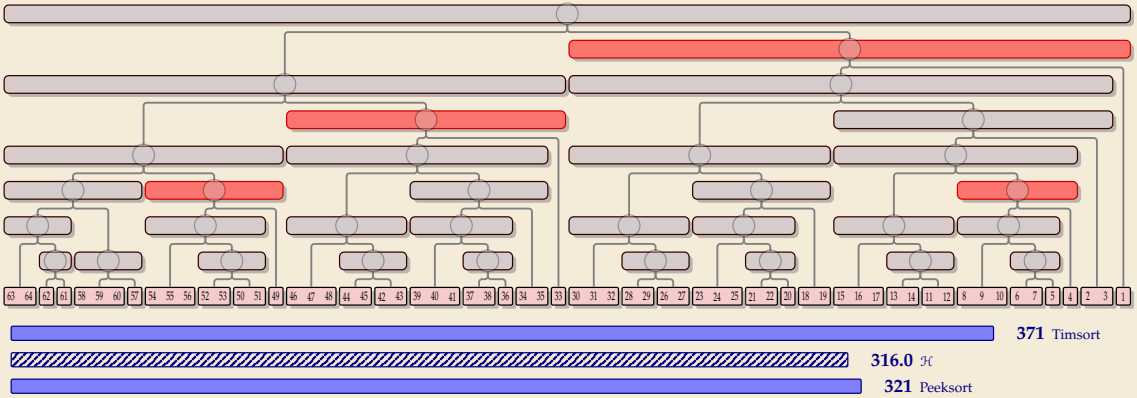
```
1 procedure Timsort(A[0..n)):
2     i := 0; runs := new Stack()
3     while i < n
4         j := ExtendRunRight(A, i)
5         runs.push(i, j); i := j
6         while rule A/B/C/D applicable
7             merge corresponding runs
8     while runs.size() ≥ 2
9         merge topmost 2 runs
```



- above shows the core algorithm;
  many more algorithm engineering tricks
- **Advantages:**
  - profits from existing runs
  - *locality of reference* for merges
- **But:** ***not*** optimally adaptive! (next slide)
  Reason: Rules A–D (Why exactly these?!)

Timsort bad case

- On certain inputs, Timsort's merge rules don't work well:



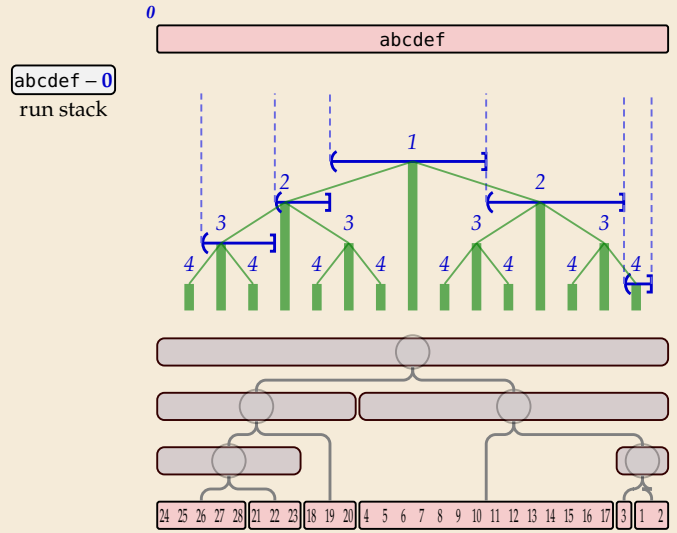
- As n increases, Timsort's cost approach $1.5 \cdot \mathcal{H}$, i. e., 50% more merge costs than necessary
  - intuitive problem: regularly very unbalanced merges

Buss, Knop: *Strategies for Stable Merge Sorting*, SODA **2019**

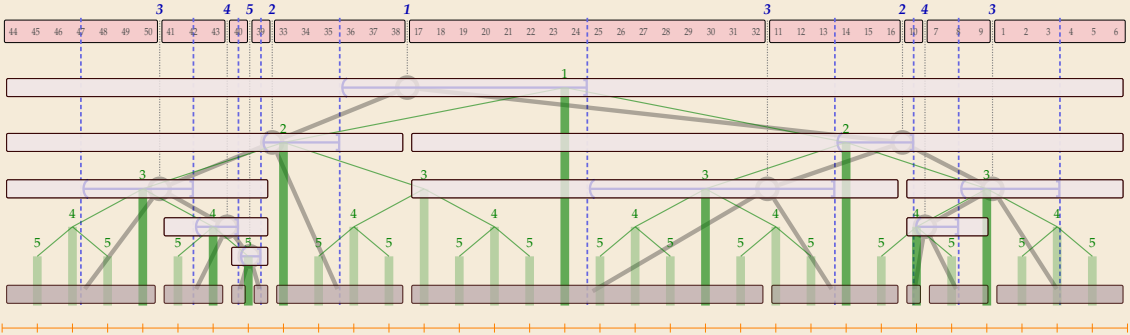
Powersort

⇝ Timsort's *merge rules* aren't great, but overall algorithm has appeal . . . can we keep that?

```
1  procedure Powersort(A[0..n)):
2      i := 0; runs := new Stack()
3      j := ExtendRunRight(A, i)
4      runs.push((i, j), 0); i := j
5      while i < n
6          j := ExtendRunRight(A, i)
7          p := power(runs.top(), (i, j), n)
8          while runs.top().power > p
9              merge topmost 2 runs
10         runs.push((i, j), p); i := j
11     while runs.size() ≥ 2
12         merge topmost 2 runs
```



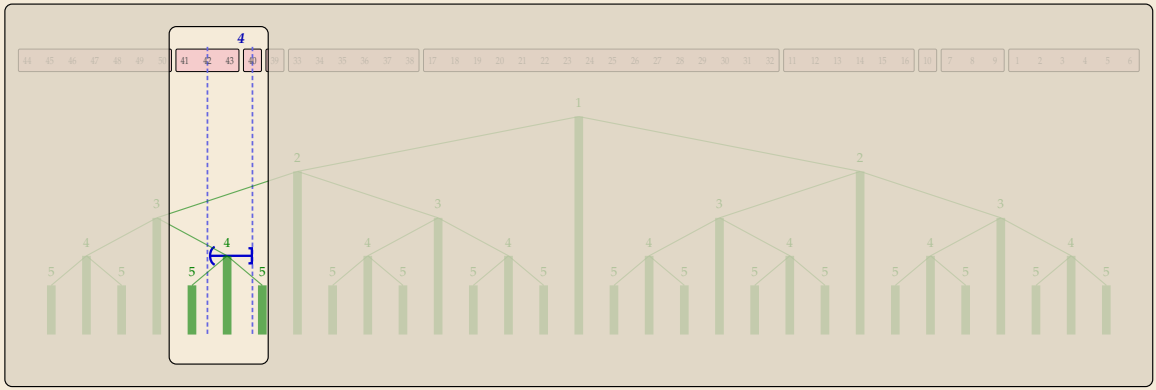
Powersort – Run-Boundary Powers



- (virtual) perfect balanced binary tree
- midpoint intervals "snap" to closest virtual tree node
  - ⇝ assigns each run boundary a depth = its *power*
- ⇝ merge tree follows virtual tree



Powersort – Run-Boundary Powers are Local

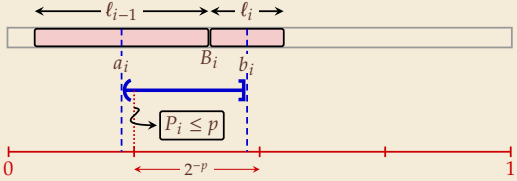


Computation of powers only depends on two adjacent runs.

Powersort – Computing powers

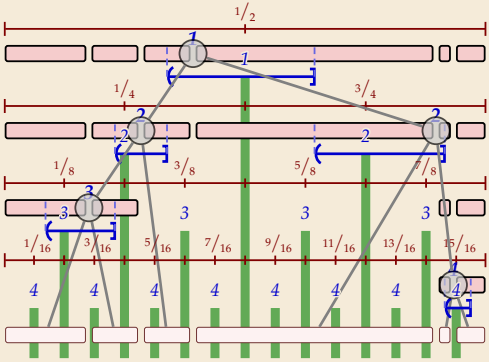
- Computing the power of (run boundary between) two runs
  - ⟷ = normalized midpoint interval
  - power = min ℓ s.t. ⟷ contains $c \cdot 2^{-\ell}$






```
1  procedure power((i1, j1), (i2, j2), n):
2      n1 := j1 − i1
3      n2 := j2 − i2
4      a := (i1 + ½n1 − 1) / n
5      b := (i2 + ½n2 − 1) / n        // interval (a, b]
6      ℓ := 0
7      while ⌊a · 2^ℓ⌋ == ⌊b · 2^ℓ⌋
8          ℓ := ℓ + 1
9      return ℓ
```

- with bitwise trickery $O(1)$ time possible



Powersort – Analysis

- **Given:** input with runs $R_1, \ldots, R_r$ of *lengths* $\ell_1, \ldots, \ell_r$;
  $n = \ell_1 + \cdots + \ell_r$
- Mergecost: $M = \sum_{r=1}^{r} \ell_i \cdot \text{depth}(R_i)$

$\rightsquigarrow\ M \ \leq\ \sum_{r=1}^{r} \ell_i \cdot \hat{P}_i$, where $\hat{P}_i = \max\{P_i, P_{i+1}\}$

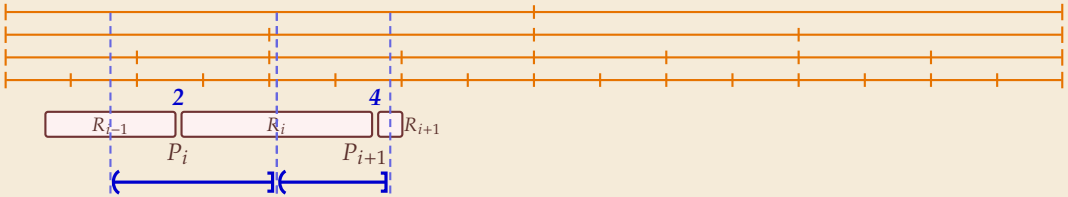
P_i = power of boundary between R_{i-1} and R_i, $i = 2, \ldots, r$
$P_1 = P_{r+1} = 0$

$\rightsquigarrow$ To prove $M \leq n(\mathcal{H}+2)$,
it suffices to show:

$P_i \quad \leq \lceil \log_2(\frac{n}{\ell_i}) + 1 \rceil \leq \log_2(\frac{n}{\ell_i}) + 2$
$P_{i+1} \leq \lceil \log_2(\frac{n}{\ell_i}) + 1 \rceil \leq \log_2(\frac{n}{\ell_i}) + 2$

- by def.: $\frac{|\longleftrightarrow|}{n} \geq 2^{-p} \quad \rightsquigarrow \quad P_i \leq p$
- we have: $|\longleftrightarrow| \ \geq\ \ell_i/2$

$\rightsquigarrow\ P_i \leq \lceil \log_2(\frac{n}{\ell_i}) \rceil + 1$ ■



Powersort – Discussion

- 👍 Retains all advantages of Timsort
  - good locality in memory accesses
  - no recursion
  - all the tricks in Timsort
- 👍 optimally adapts to existing runs
- 👍 minimal overhead for finding merge order